during the Cold War, artists and writers shaped the afterlife of the Berlin Wall in an extended critical exercise on newly cohering historical lessons and emergent forms and sites of division.[12]

As demonstrated throughout this book, American cultural producers and consumers had regularly turned to the Berlin Wall as a site where Cold War freedom and repression, history and identity, could be put to the test. Compellingly drawn to the divided city, the American Berliners of this book were profoundly moved by their encounters by the Wall and worked to consider the ways their American identity could be critically explored. Their works would fuel the discoveries of subsequent cohorts who, after 1989, continued to make pilgrimages to the city and the footprint of the former Wall. For those who had routinely visited the city before—Freed, Davis, Tajiri, and Lorde—the events of 1989 prompted returns and critical observations about what this former division signified. None of them had anticipated the dismantling of the Wall. But their eager returns to the city were marked by individual, deep connections with Berliners, as well as tempered reflections about the upheavals associated with historical change. Through new works or continued projects about Berlin, they tracked the Wall's transformation from geopolitical barricade to site of politicized memory and cultural commodity. Each person continued on paths they had already pursued, by returning to Berlin for critical and creative explorations and connecting new visions back to previous ideas about global freedoms and restraints near the Wall.

Just as he saw the Berlin Wall go up in August 1961, Leonard Freed returned on November 12, 1989, days after the border was breached, and documented scenes at the newly opened border. Freed took his time to reexplore the city and consider the evolution of military occupation and cultural connection on both sides of the former wall. In the days after the border was breached, he first captured images of an East German soldier standing outside the Neue Wache, the GDR war memorial on Unter den Linden (fig. 5.1). Experiencing an extreme moment of geopolitical flux, Freed recalled of that day, "Yesterday, if he had smiled while on guard duty this East German soldier would have been court-martialed. Today he can smile because he knows it will soon be over, the Wall has been breached."[13] Freed photographed the guard several times, from up close, waiting to get a frame in which he smiled back at the camera. Freed returned for Germany's official reunification ceremony in October 1990, viewing the events from